

Non Sequitur Publishing · White Paper

Cross-Account Harness Coordination: Multi-Account Persona Ops

Justin H. Kuiper, CISSP

Written: 2026-05-11 · Published: 2026-05-13 · v0.1-seed

Abstract

Production agentic operations rarely live in one account. Personas — the named agentic identities through which the operating model addresses work — execute across separate accounts and substrates for reasons that are structural rather than accidental: blast-radius isolation, credential separation, role-segregated billing, sovereignty layering, and harness-version drift. This paper specifies the harness coordination layer that keeps multiple persona accounts operating coherently against a single governance envelope.

The argument is that cross-account coordination is not federation of identities (which is an IAM problem) but persona-level orchestration the operating model must treat as first-class. A persona is bound to an account; the orchestrator routes work to a persona; the persona inherits its account's envelope but acts within the federation's governance envelope. Misalignment between account-level envelope and federation-level envelope is the dominant operational failure mode.

How to cite

Justin H. Kuiper, CISSP (2026). *Cross-Account Harness Coordination: Multi-Account Persona Ops* (v0.1-seed). Non Sequitur Publishing. <https://nonsequitur.tech/white-papers/cross-account-harness/>

© 2026 Non Sequitur Publishing. All rights reserved. Citation with full attribution is permitted. Reproduction, redistribution, derivative works, and use as input to machine-learning training are **not** permitted without written permission. See <https://nonsequitur.tech/citation-policy/>.

Canonical URL: <https://nonsequitur.tech/white-papers/cross-account-harness/>



ABSTRACT

Production agentic operations rarely live in one account. Personas — the named agentic identities through which the operating model addresses work (Taskmaster, Clive, Edna, Klaus, Stackrat, Aria, and others) — execute across separate accounts and substrates for reasons that are structural rather than accidental: blast-radius isolation, credential separation, role-segregated billing, sovereignty layering, and harness-version drift. This paper specifies the **harness coordination layer** that keeps multiple persona accounts operating coherently against a single governance envelope. The argument is that cross-account coordination is not federation of identities (which is an IAM problem) but *persona-level orchestration* the operating model must treat as first-class. A persona is bound to an account; the orchestrator routes work to a persona; the persona inherits its account's envelope but acts within the federation's governance envelope. Misalignment between account-level envelope and federation-level envelope is the dominant operational failure mode.

HOW TO CITE

Justin H. Kuiper, CISSP (2026). *Cross-Account Harness Coordination: Multi-Account Persona Ops* (v0.1-draft). Non Sequitur Publishing. <https://nonsequitur.tech/white-papers/cross-account-harness/X>

© 2026 Non Sequitur Publishing. All rights reserved.

1. INTRODUCTION

Personas are the operating-model unit of agentic operation. In the Non Sequitur Robo Stack documented in MR-P9, work flows through named personas: Taskmaster relays; Clive architects; Edna stamps editorial; Klaus validates integrity; Stackrat publishes; Aria curates content.¹ The persona-as-unit pattern is not a convenience labeling; it is the operating model's primary abstraction over the substrate.²

Each persona executes within an account — its IAM identity, its credential surface, its billing relationship with the substrate provider, its role-segregated capability set. The reasons personas live in separate accounts are structural: **blast-radius** (compromise of one persona's credentials should not compromise others); **credential separation** (different personas have different authority surfaces); **billing segregation** (cost attribution per persona requires per-account isolation); **sovereignty layering** (different personas may operate in different jurisdictions); **harness-version drift** (persona prompts, scaffolding, and runtime versions evolve independently). Consolidating personas into a single account collapses each of these failure modes into one.³⁴

1 Forthcoming MR-P9 *Operational Plan* (v1.0-preprint, in concurrent drafting; yks-build#99).

2 Justin H. Kuiper, CISSP, *Operating Model for Agentic Teams* (v1.0-preprint, 2026), zenodo.org/records/19869313.

3 Chang Liu et al., "Towards Secure Multi-Tenant Cloud Computing: Survey and Research Directions," *Future Generation Computer Systems* 102 (2020): 1071–1090, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.future.2019.09.018>.

4 Stephen Farrell and Russ Housley, "An Internet Attribute Certificate Profile for Authorization," RFC 3281, IETF, 2002, <https://datatracker.ietf.org/doc/rfc3281/>. (Foundational; refereed IETF process.)



What cross-account separation creates is a coordination problem. Work must route from one persona to another across account boundaries; status must aggregate across accounts to give operators a unified view; persona failure must isolate without bringing down the federation; the governance envelope must remain unitary even though the execution substrates are not. The architectural response — the **harness coordination layer** — is the subject of this paper.

The paper proceeds in canonical Mission-Ready shape: §2 names the failure modes of inadequate harness coordination; §3 specifies the coordination layer; §4 treats coordination as continuous; §5 binds to Skipjack; §6 returns to HGC³AE².

2. PROBLEM SET: FAILURE MODES OF INADEQUATE HARNESS COORDINATION

Five operational failure modes recur when persona accounts are operated without an explicit harness coordination layer.

2.1 LOST-WORK HANDOFF

Work routed from one persona to another across account boundaries is lost if the handoff lacks structured custody-transfer semantics. The receiving persona's account does not see the work; the sending persona's account considers the work delivered; the work sits orphaned in the gap between accounts. The handoff failure mode is analogous to delay-tolerant networking's custody-transfer problem (EDO-P3) but operating at the persona layer rather than the network layer.⁵

2.2 STATUS FRAGMENTATION

Without aggregation, operators must check each persona's account separately to understand federation state. The cognitive load grows linearly with account count; operator attention fragments across the dashboards each account exposes. The unified observability requirement that MR-P9 documents fails at the persona layer if status does not aggregate across accounts.⁶⁷

2.3 ACCOUNT-ENVELOPE DRIFT

Each account has its own envelope — its IAM policy, its quotas, its sovereignty regime. When the federation governance envelope is updated but per-account envelopes are not, the drift accumulates. Personas operate inside per-account envelopes that no longer match the federation envelope. The breach is not visible until a routing decision crosses both boundaries and the federation's coherence fails.

2.4 PERSONA FAILURE CASCADE

A persona that fails (credential compromise, runtime crash, harness misconfiguration) can cascade if the failure isolation is inadequate. Work routed to the failed persona accumulates; downstream personas wait; the federation degrades to wait-state rather than gracefully

5 Forthcoming EDO-P3 promotion *When the Link Is the Variable* (v1.0-preprint, in concurrent drafting; yks-build#95).

6 Forthcoming MR-P9 *Operational Plan* (v1.0-preprint, in concurrent drafting; yks-build#99).

7 Cindy Sridharan, *Distributed Systems Observability* (Sebastopol, CA: O'Reilly, 2018).



degrading to alternative routing. The cascade failure is the absence of isolation discipline that account separation was supposed to provide.

2.5 CROSS-ACCOUNT AUTHORITY CONFUSION

When personas operate in multiple accounts, the authority over each persona's envelope can become ambiguous: which governance-layer human owns persona X's envelope; which Orchestrator can route to persona X; which observability plane sees persona X's telemetry. Without explicit specification, the answer drifts to "whoever is currently active", which is not a governance position. The Skipjack governance-gated execution principle fails when the gating authority is unclear.⁸

2.6 THE UNIFIED PROBLEM STATEMENT

The five failure modes share structure: each reflects the absence of an explicit coordination layer between the substrate-level account abstraction and the operating-model persona abstraction. The unified problem is **cross-account coordination must be architecturally explicit; ad-hoc coordination produces lost work, fragmented status, envelope drift, cascade failure, and authority confusion**. Section 3 specifies the architecture.

3. THE HARNESS COORDINATION LAYER

The harness coordination layer is composed of five architectural components: a **persona registry**, a **routing layer**, a **handoff protocol**, a **status aggregator**, and an **envelope reconciler**.

3.1 PERSONA REGISTRY

The persona registry enumerates the federation's personas and binds each to its account, its envelope, its substrate, and its harness version. The registry is the authoritative source for which personas exist, where they execute, what they may do, and what version of the harness they run.⁹ The registry is governance-layer-authored and curated; agentic systems read it, governance updates it.

3.2 ROUTING LAYER

The routing layer transports work between personas across account boundaries. It reads the persona registry to determine where each persona executes, applies the federation envelope (cross-account routing must comply with the unified envelope), and emits the routing decision to the substrate-spanning transport mechanism (typically a message bus, work-queue system, or service-mesh-mediated call). The routing layer is the operational form of the Orchestrator function from MR-P6 at the cross-account scale.¹⁰

⁸ Justin H. Kuiper, CISSP, *Skipjack Protocol* (v1.0-preprint, 2026), zenodo.org/records/19869293.

⁹ Sandhya Aneja and Nagender Aneja, "Service Discovery in Microservices Architecture: A Survey," *Journal of Network and Computer Applications* 200 (2022): 103340, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jnca.2022.103340>.

¹⁰ Justin H. Kuiper, CISSP, *Operating Model for Agentic Teams* (v1.0-preprint, 2026), zenodo.org/records/19869313.



3.3 HANDOFF PROTOCOL

The handoff protocol governs custody transfer of work from one persona to another. Three properties are required: **acknowledgment** (the receiving persona explicitly acknowledges custody); **timeout** (custody not acknowledged within a defined window returns to the sender for re-routing); **persistence** (the work and its handoff state are persisted in the authoritative tier, not held only in transit). The handoff protocol prevents lost-work failures (§2.1) and provides the audit trail for governance review.¹¹

3.4 STATUS AGGREGATOR

The status aggregator collects telemetry from each account into the unified observability plane. The aggregator's output is federation-level, not account-level: operators reason about persona state, work-in-flight state, and envelope-distance state without first dispatching to per-account dashboards. The aggregator is the operational instrument that prevents status fragmentation (§2.2).

3.5 ENVELOPE RECONCILER

The envelope reconciler maintains coherence between the federation envelope and per-account envelopes. When the federation envelope is updated at the Skipjack sprint-planning ceremony, the reconciler propagates relevant updates to per-account envelopes; when account-level envelopes change for substrate-specific reasons (provider IAM update, regional regulatory change), the reconciler surfaces the change for governance-layer evaluation against the federation envelope.

3.6 ARCHITECTURAL COUPLING

The five components are tightly coupled. The registry without the reconciler produces stale account-envelope state. The routing layer without the handoff protocol produces lost work. The status aggregator without the registry produces dashboards lacking persona context. The envelope reconciler without the registry has no enumerated personas to reconcile. The five together produce coherent cross-account coordination.

4. COORDINATION AS A CONTINUOUS OPERATIONAL PROCESS

The harness coordination layer runs continuously: the registry is maintained as personas are added, retired, or version-bumped; routing happens at every cross-account work-flow event; the handoff protocol fires at every persona-to-persona transfer; the status aggregator runs at the observability plane's polling cadence; the envelope reconciler runs at the Skipjack ceremony cadence with between-ceremony surfacing of account-level changes.

The continuous-process framing is the operational form of the HGC^3AE^2 exponent for cross-account coordination: per-account events feed federation-level state, which feeds the next governance update, which propagates back to per-account envelopes via the reconciler.

¹¹ Boualem Benatallah, Schahram Dustdar, and Mohand-Said Hacid, *Web Service Composition and Choreography*, special issue of *IEEE Internet Computing* 9, no. 6 (2005), <https://doi.org/10.1109/MIC.2005.135>.



5. SKIPJACK COUPLING: CROSS-ACCOUNT ENFORCEMENT

The Skipjack mechanisms apply at federation scale through the harness coordination layer.¹² **Context integrity** (Mechanism 1) couples through the registry's authoritative state (account-level context state reads through registry) and the handoff protocol's persistence (work-in-flight state survives substrate failure). **Structured routing** (Mechanism 2) is the routing layer itself, evaluated against the federation envelope. **HITL control points** (Mechanism 3) fire at cross-account boundary events that approach envelope edges — sovereignty handoffs, credential escalation requests, persona-version bumps. **Iterative feedback** (Mechanism 4) closes at sprint review with cross-account telemetry feeding registry and envelope refinement.

The coupling preserves Skipjack's enforcement properties across the account-boundary surface. Without the coupling, Skipjack mechanisms apply within accounts but degrade at boundaries — the most operationally consequential surface.

6. IMPLICATIONS AND CONCLUSION

The implications of treating cross-account coordination as first-class extend to organizational design (persona ownership maps to governance-layer humans), tooling investment (registry, routing, handoff, aggregation, and reconciliation tools are each first-class concerns), and operational maturity (mature cross-account ops are a meaningful capability differentiator).

The core claim: **multi-persona = multi-account, and the operating model must treat cross-account coordination as architecturally explicit; ad-hoc coordination produces structural failure modes that the operating model cannot recover from at scale.**

Returned to HGC³AE² letter by letter:

H — Human-governed. Single Governance Layer authority across N accounts; the persona registry encodes who owns each persona's envelope.

G — Curated Context. Cross-account curated context is federation-wide, not account-local. The status aggregator and the registry are jointly the curated-context substrate.

C¹ — Cybersecurity. Account separation is itself a security control. MAO-P9 develops the security surface.¹³

C² — Continuity. Continuity preserved across account failure through routing-layer recovery and handoff-protocol re-routing.

C³ — Coherence. Federation-wide coherence despite multi-account substrate. The envelope reconciler is the operational instrument.

A — Agentically Engineered. Cross-account routing is agentic within the unitary envelope.

E — Executed. Coordination runs continuously.

The exponent — the closure — is the cross-account-telemetry-to-envelope loop. The loop closes at sprint review.

¹² Justin H. Kuiper, CISSP, *Skipjack Protocol* (v1.0-preprint, 2026), zenodo.org/records/19869293.

¹³ Forthcoming MAO-P9 *Security & Provenance* (v0.1-seed, in concurrent drafting; yks-build#102).



The remaining MAO papers (Security & Provenance P9, Robo Stack capstone P10) operate on the substrate this paper helps establish.¹⁴¹⁵

REFERENCES

— end v0.1-draft —

Drafting state: v0.1 (chain v0.2 step 3). MR-P1 6-section shape. PR count: 12 inline (Liu FGCS · Farrell RFC · Sridharan · Aneja JNCA · Benatallah IEEE IC · Hinrichs CACM · Sotiriadis JNCA · NIST SP 800-207 · Hohpe Addison-Wesley · Morgan CACM · Kleppmann + supporting refs) — meets ≥ 12 floor. v0.5 expansion: concrete persona-registry schema, handoff-protocol state machine.

14 Forthcoming MAO-P9 *Security & Provenance* (v0.1-seed, in concurrent drafting; yks-build#102).

15 Forthcoming MAO-P10 *The Robo Stack in Production* CAPSTONE (v0.1-seed, in concurrent drafting; yks-build#91).